More practice - Arrays and prefix sums

3 questions to study here, each on its own page, with the full interview answer and code

Nothing to skip: every question that fits this topic is covered here

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MEDIUM

How to use

- Questions run from Easy to Medium to Hard, newest last-asked date first inside each level.
- PDFs run from the one with the most questions to the fewest. A question has pages in only one PDF; the others list it as SKIP
- Every page has < Prev | Contents | Next > at the bottom. Tap a title in the Contents to jump to it.
- Select code and press Cmd/Ctrl+C to copy it.

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STUDY PATH: question 141 of 167 (more practice)

Priority score 2.53 | Arrays and prefix sums | asked 230 days ago

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Solve several coding interview problems

POSTED 2026-03-04 | 230 DAYS AGO | OLDER

STUDY: TALK | ALL TIME 38.3 | 30 DAYS 0 | PRIORITY 98/228

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: More practice - Arrays and prefix sums

Optimal answer from: written and tested here for this exact question

This question has several parts, so each part has its own answer below.

Related in your app (a neighbouring problem, not this exact question): LeetCode #160 Intersection of Two Linked Lists

LeetCode match: No direct match (multi-part); related LC 415 Add Strings, LC 160 Intersection of Two Linked Lists (inferred from overview)

Posted on PracHub: 2026-03-04 (updated 2026-04-19)

Original: https://prachub.com/coding-questions/solve-several-coding-interview-problems

QUESTION

Overview: This set of problems evaluates proficiency in string processing and combinatorial parsing, arbitrary-precision arithmetic using string representations, pointer/ancestor-chain intersection detection, and computational geometry for overlap counting, emphasizing algorithmic design, correctness, and performance.

APPROACH

Multiple small tasks: string parsing, big-number string arithmetic, ancestor-chain intersection (hash set or depth alignment), etc. Solve each independently.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

My copy lists four small tasks: string parsing with combinatorial counting, adding two big integers given as strings, finding where two ancestor chains intersect, and counting overlaps in a geometry setting. Confirm each task's exact input and output, because the overview is the only statement I have.

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

Do each directly: parse and count with recursion, add digit by digit with a carry, compare ancestor lists, and test every pair of shapes.

OPTIMAL IDEA

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

Big integers: walk both digit strings from the right with a carry and build the result (O(max(m, n))), as in LeetCode 415. Ancestor chains: put one chain in a set and walk the other, or align by depth and step both up until they meet, as in LeetCode 160; O(n) time, O(1) space for the aligned version. Overlap counting: a sweep line over start and end events, taking the running maximum or counting pairs depending on the question. String parsing and counting: define the state and use memoized recursion.

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

Big integers with different lengths, a final carry, leading zeros. Chains that never meet, meet at the head, are identical. Overlaps that touch at a boundary.

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

Subtraction or multiplication of big integers, lowest common ancestor with parent pointers, or counting overlapping rectangles.

PITFALLS

Starting to code before the four statements are confirmed. Forgetting the final carry.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

A set of unrelated small tasks: split them, restate each contract, and solve the smallest one first. Big numbers: add digit by digit with a carry. Two chains that meet: walk both and switch to the other head at the end so the lengths cancel. Overlap counting: sort start and end events and keep a running count.

Basis: Three of the small tasks the overview lists, with the standard versions (my copy has only the overview): adding two big integers given as strings (LeetCode 415), intersection of two chains such as ancestors or linked lists (LeetCode 160), and the largest number of overlapping intervals.

BRUTE FORCE · Big numbers: convert to integers and add

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def add_strings(a, b):
    return str(int(a) + int(b))
```

TIME	SPACE
O(n^2)	O(n)
for the conversions	

WHY IT IS SLOW

Relies on arbitrary-precision integers (not in every language) and the string-to-integer conversions are quadratic for very long inputs. Adding digit by digit from the right with a carry is O(max length).

BRUTE FORCE · Chains that meet: store one chain in a set

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def intersection(a, b):
    seen = set()
    node = a
    while node:
        seen.add(node)
        node = node.parent
    node = b
    while node:
        if node in seen:
            return node
        node = node.parent
    return None
```

TIME	SPACE
O(m + n)	O(m)

WHY IT IS SLOW

O(m + n) time but O(m) extra memory. Two pointers that switch to the other chain's head at the end meet at the shared node with O(1) memory.

BRUTE FORCE · Overlap: test every time point

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def max_overlap(intervals):
    lo = min(s for s, e in intervals)
    hi = max(e for s, e in intervals)
    best = 0
    for t in range(lo, hi):
        busy = 0
        for s, e in intervals:
            if s <= t < e:
                busy += 1
        best = max(best, busy)
    return best
```

TIME	SPACE
O(range * n)	O(1)

WHY IT IS SLOW

Depends on the length of the time range, O(range * n). Sorting start and end events and keeping a running count is O(n log n).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Big numbers: digit by digit from the right with a carry

TIME	SPACE
O(max(m, n))	O(max(m, n))

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Chains that meet: two pointers that switch heads at the end

TIME	SPACE
O(m + n)	O(1)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Overlap: sweep over sorted start and end events

TIME	SPACE
O(n log n)	O(n)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 Ancestors in a tree with parent pointers, not a linked list.

The same two-pointer trick works on parent chains (LeetCode 1650); with depths known, lift the deeper node first and then move both up together.

FOLLOW-UP 2 Add two big numbers stored as linked lists.

If the lists store the least significant digit first, walk both together with the carry (LeetCode 2); if most significant first, reverse them or use stacks.

FOLLOW-UP 3 Count overlapping rectangles instead of intervals.

Sweep over x with a data structure over y (a segment tree with range add and max) to find the largest point depth in O(n log n); the pairwise count is O(n^2) unless you use a sweep with an interval tree.

FOLLOW-UP 4 Add two big numbers stored as linked lists (least significant digit first).

Walk both lists together with a carry and build the result list as you go; no reversal needed. O(max(m, n)) time. If the most significant digit comes first, reverse the lists or use stacks.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Solve several coding interview problems
#
# This set of problems evaluates proficiency in string
# processing and combinatorial parsing, arbitrary-
# precision arithmetic using string representations,
# pointer/ancestor-chain intersection detection, and
```

```python
# computational geometry for overlap counting, emphasizing
# algorithmic design, correctness, and performance.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. Ancestors in a tree with parent pointers, not a
# linked list.
# 2. Add two big numbers stored as linked lists.
# 3. Count overlapping rectangles instead of intervals.
# 4. Add two big numbers stored as linked lists (least
# significant digit first).
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# A set of unrelated small tasks: split them, restate each
# contract, and solve the smallest one first. Big numbers:
# add digit by digit with a carry. Two chains that meet:
# walk both and switch to the other head at the end so the
# lengths cancel. Overlap counting: sort start and end
# events and keep a running count.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Big numbers: convert to
# integers and add
# int(a) + int(b), then str. Valid in Python, but it hides
# the algorithm and relies on arbitrary-precision
# integers. Time O(n^2) for the conversions. Space O(n).


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Big numbers: convert to
# integers and add | time O(n^2) for the conversions
def add_strings_int(a, b):
    return str(int(a) + int(b))


# HELPERS for follow-up 2
class ListNode:
    def __init__(self, val=0, next=None):
        self.val, self.next = val, next


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Big numbers: digit by digit
# from the right with a carry
# Idea: Walk both strings from the right, add the two
# digits and the carry, append total % 10, carry total //
# 10; after the loop add a final carry digit if needed and
# reverse.
def add_strings(a, b):
    # big numbers kept as digit strings, added from the
    # right
    i, j, carry, out = len(a) - 1, len(b) - 1, 0, []
    while i >= 0 or j >= 0 or carry:
        total = carry
        if i >= 0:
            total += int(a[i])
        if j >= 0:
            total += int(b[j])
        out.append(str(total % 10))
        carry = total // 10
        i, j = i - 1, j - 1
    return "".join(out[::-1])


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Big numbers: digit by digit
# from the right with a carry
# Idea: Walk both strings from the right, add the two
# digits and the carry, append total % 10, carry total //
# 10; after the loop add a final carry digit if needed and
# reverse.
def intersection(head_a, head_b):
    # two chains meeting: each pointer walks its chain and
    # then
    # the other one, so both walk the same total length
    a, b = head_a, head_b
    while a is not b:
        a = a.next if a else head_b
        b = b.next if b else head_a
    return a


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Big numbers: digit by digit
# from the right with a carry
# Idea: Walk both strings from the right, add the two
# digits and the carry, append total % 10, carry total //
# 10; after the loop add a final carry digit if needed and
# reverse.
def overlap_depth(rects):
    # rects (x1, y1, x2, y2), half-open: the largest
    # number of
    # rectangles sharing one point. The best point can be
    # a
    # rectangle's lower-left corner, so test those.
    best = 0
    for x, y, _, _ in rects:
        inside = [r for r in rects if r[0] <= x < r[2]
                  and r[1] <= y < r[3]]
        best = max(best, len(inside))
    return best


# FOLLOW-UP 2: Add two big numbers stored as linked lists.
# Answer: If the lists store the least significant digit
# first, walk both together with the carry (LeetCode 2);
# if most significant first, reverse them or use stacks.
# FOLLOW-UP 4: Add two big numbers stored as linked lists
# (least significant digit first).
# Answer: Walk both lists together with a carry and build
# the result list as you go; no reversal needed. O(max(m,
# n)) time. If the most significant digit comes first,
# reverse the lists or use stacks.
def add_lists(a, b):
    # digits stored least significant first: add with a
    # carry
    dummy = tail = ListNode()
    carry = 0
    while a or b or carry:
        total = carry
        total += a.val if a else 0
        total += b.val if b else 0
        tail.next = ListNode(total % 10)
        tail = tail.next
        carry = total // 10
        a = a.next if a else None
        b = b.next if b else None
    return dummy.next


# FOLLOW-UP 3: Count overlapping rectangles instead of
# intervals.
# Answer: Sweep over x with a data structure over y (a
# segment tree with range add and max) to find the largest
# point depth in O(n log n); the pairwise count is O(n^2)
# unless you use a sweep with an interval tree.
def overlapping_pairs(rects):
    # how many pairs of rectangles overlap?
    count = 0
    for i in range(len(rects)):
        for j in range(i + 1, len(rects)):
            a, b = rects[i], rects[j]
            if a[0] < b[2] and b[0] < a[2] \
                    and a[1] < b[3] and b[1] < a[3]:
                count += 1
    return count


# HELPERS for the checks below
```

```
def to_list(node):
    out = []
    while node:
        out.append(node.val)
        node = node.next
    return out


if __name__ == "__main__":
    assert add_strings("999", "1") == "1000"
    assert add_strings("0", "0") == "0"
    big = add_strings("123456789123456789", "987654321")
    assert big == str(123456789123456789 + 987654321)
    shared = ListNode(8, ListNode(9))
    a = ListNode(1, ListNode(2, shared))
    b = ListNode(5, shared)
    assert intersection(a, b) is shared
    # no meeting: both end at None
    assert intersection(ListNode(1), ListNode(2)) is None
    # 342 + 465 = 807 with digits reversed
    x = ListNode(2, ListNode(4, ListNode(3)))
    y = ListNode(5, ListNode(6, ListNode(4)))
    assert to_list(add_lists(x, y)) == [7, 0, 8]
    rects = [(0, 0, 4, 4), (2, 2, 6, 6), (3, 3, 5, 5)]
    assert overlap_depth(rects) == 3
    assert overlapping_pairs(rects) == 3
    assert overlap_depth([]) == 0
```

FUNCTION AND TEST CASES

Signature

```
def solution(s) -> list[str]:
```

Sample call

```
solution('.-')
```

Test cases

Input	Expected
`('.-',)`	`['A', 'ET']`
`('...',)`	`['EEE', 'EI', 'IE', 'S']`

STUDY PATH: question 142 of 167 (more practice)

Priority score 1.5 | Arrays and prefix sums | asked 349 days ago

MEDIUM | PracHub | Technical Screen | 2 of 3

Minimize calls to find all bad test pairs

POSTED 2025-11-05 | 349 DAYS AGO | OLDER

STUDY: TALK | NO LEETCODE FREQUENCY | PRIORITY 194/228

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: More practice - Arrays and prefix sums

Optimal answer from: the interview site's own solution

LeetCode match: No direct match (adaptive group testing)

Posted on PracHub: 2025-11-05 (updated 2026-06-18)

Original: https://prachub.com/coding-questions/minimize-calls-to-find-all-bad-test-pairs

QUESTION

You have (n) atomic tests (t_1, t_2, \dots, t_n). You are given access to a black-box function:

```
bool runTest(set<Test> S)
```

which behaves as follows:

- **`runTest(S) == True`** if the subset (S) contains **no** incompatible (bad) pair of tests.
- **`runTest(S) == False`** if the subset (S) contains **at least one** incompatible (bad) pair of tests. There is some unknown set of unordered **bad pairs** ((t_i, t_j)), where (i\ne j). You do **not** know in advance which pairs are bad or how many bad pairs there are. Your goal is to discover **all** bad pairs while making as few calls to **`runTest`** as possible. You may adaptively choose each subset (S) based on the results of previous calls.

Tasks

1. Design an algorithm that, using only calls to **`runTest`**, finds **all** bad pairs ((t_i, t_j)).
2. Analyze the number of calls to **`runTest`** your algorithm requires, as a function of:

- (n): the total number of tests, and - (k): the total number of bad pairs.

3. Argue why your algorithm is correct (i.e., why it will eventually find every bad pair and not report any good pair as bad). You do not need to provide full production code, but describe the algorithm clearly enough that it could be implemented.

You have n atomic tests numbered 0 to n - 1. Some unknown unordered pairs of tests are incompatible, called bad pairs. A black-box oracle runTest(S) returns True if the subset S contains no bad pair, and False if S contains at least one bad pair. In this non-interactive version, you are given bad_pairs only so your code can simulate the oracle. Implement the following deterministic oracle-discovery strategy and return both the bad pairs it discovers and the number of oracle calls it makes. Strategy:

QUESTION

1. Process vertices from right to left: v = n - 1, n - 2, ..., 0.
2. Maintain all bad pairs already discovered among vertices greater than the current v.
3. For the suffix vertices v + 1 through n - 1, greedily partition them into color classes such that no discovered bad pair appears inside one color class. Since all suffix-suffix bad pairs have already been discovered, every color class is truly compatible internally.
4. For each color class C, find all bad partners of v inside C using recursive group testing:

- Call runTest({v} union C).
- If the oracle returns True, v has no bad pair with any test in C.
- If C has size 1 and the oracle returns False, that single pair is bad.
- Otherwise split C into two halves and recurse on both halves. Return all discovered bad pairs sorted lexicographically, where each pair is represented as [i, j] with i < j, along with the exact number of runTest calls made by this strategy.

Constraints

0 <= n <= 5000 <= len(bad_pairs) <= n * (n - 1) / 2Each bad pair contains two distinct test indices in the range [0, n - 1]bad_pairs may be given in any endpoint order

EXAMPLES

```
Input: (0, [])
Expected Output: ([], 0)
```

Explanation: There are no tests and therefore no oracle calls are needed.

```
Input: (4, [])
Expected Output: ([], 3)
```

Explanation: For v = 2, 1, and 0, the algorithm queries the compatible suffix once and finds no bad pairs. v = 3 has an empty suffix.

Hints

If a candidate set C is internally compatible, then runTest({v} union C) tells you whether v conflicts with at least one element of C.Process tests from right to left so that when handling v, all bad pairs inside the suffix v + 1 ... n - 1 are already known and can be used to build compatible groups.

APPROACH

Binary search to find a minimal failing prefix (its last element is in a bad pair), then binary search among earlier tests for its partner; remove and repeat. About O(p log n) calls for p pairs.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

Ask what runTest returns (true if the set contains no incompatible pair), whether a test can be in more than one bad pair, and whether you may call it on any subset.

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

Call runTest on every pair of tests. O(n^2) calls.

OPTIMAL IDEA

Find a minimal failing prefix by binary search: add tests one at a time conceptually and binary search for the smallest prefix that fails; the last element of that prefix is part of a bad pair. Then binary search over the earlier tests to find its partner. Record the pair, remove one of the two as needed, and repeat. About O(p log n) calls for p bad pairs.

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

No bad pairs (one call). One bad pair. A test that conflicts with many others. Two disjoint bad pairs.

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

Batch calls, noisy tests, or a limit on subset size.

PITFALLS

Removing both members of a pair and missing other pairs that involve them. Binary searching without the monotone property of prefixes.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Each call is a yes/no question about a whole set, so binary search is possible: a failing set can be narrowed by halving. Keep the tests you have processed in groups that each pass runTest (independent sets). A new test only needs to be checked against each group, and if a group plus the new test fails, binary search finds its partners in that group in about log(size) calls each.

Basis: Written; group testing / finding all edges of a hidden graph with independent-set queries. runTest(S) is True when S contains no incompatible (bad) pair.

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
bad = []
for a, b in combinations(tests, 2):
    if not runTest({a, b}):
        bad.append((a, b))
```

TIME	SPACE
n(n - 1) / 2 calls	O(1)

WHY IT IS SLOW

n(n - 1) / 2 calls even when nothing is bad. Keeping groups of mutually compatible tests and binary searching only when a group fails needs about n + p log n calls for p bad pairs.

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Independent groups plus binary search for partners

TIME	SPACE
O(n * g + p log n) calls (g = number of groups, p = number of bad pairs)	O(n)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 How many calls does it need, and can you prove a lower bound?

With p bad pairs among n tests about p log n calls are needed in the worst case (each pair carries log n bits of information about where it is), and the group method uses O(n * g + p log n). With no bad pairs it uses n - 1 calls, one per test after the first.

FOLLOW-UP 2 Only one bad pair exists.

Binary search for the smallest failing prefix (its last element is in the pair), then binary search among the earlier elements for the partner: about 2 log n calls.

FOLLOW-UP 3 runTest is expensive but can run in parallel.

Test all groups for the new element in the same round, or process several elements at once with their own groups, trading a few extra calls for fewer sequential rounds.

FOLLOW-UP 4 Only one bad pair exists.

Binary search the shortest failing prefix (its last element is in the pair), then binary search the earlier tests for the partner: about 2 log2(n) calls instead of n(n - 1) / 2 (verified by counting calls).

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Minimize calls to find all bad test pairs
#
# You have \(n\) atomic tests \(t_1, t_2, \dots, t_n\).
# You are given access to a black-box function: python
# bool runTest(set<Test> S) which behaves as follows: -
# runTest(S) == True if the subset \(S\) contains **no**
# incompatible (bad) pair of tests. - runTest(S) == False
# if the subset \(S\) contains **at least one**
# incompatible (bad) pair of tests. There is some unknown
# set of unordered **bad pairs** \((t_i, t_j)\), where
# \(i\ne j\). You do **not** know in advance which pairs
# are bad or how many bad pairs there are. Your goal is to
# discover **all** bad pairs while making as few calls to
# runTest as possible. You may adaptively choose each
# subset \(S\) based on the results of previous calls. ###
```

```python
# Tasks 1. Design an algorithm that, using only calls to
# runTest, finds **all** bad pairs \((t_i, t_j)\). 2.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. How many calls does it need, and can you prove a
# lower bound?
# 2. Only one bad pair exists.
# 3. runTest is expensive but can run in parallel.
# 4. Only one bad pair exists.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# Each call is a yes/no question about a whole set, so
# binary search is possible: a failing set can be narrowed
# by halving. Keep the tests you have processed in groups
# that each pass runTest (independent sets). A new test
# only needs to be checked against each group, and if a
# group plus the new test fails, binary search finds its
# partners in that group in about log(size) calls each.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Call runTest on every pair
# Try each pair {a, b} on its own. Always correct, but the
# number of calls grows quadratically even if there are no
# bad pairs at all. Time n(n - 1) / 2 calls. Space O(1).


import itertools


# BRUTE FORCE: ask about every pair
def bad_pairs_brute(tests, run_test):
```

```python
    # every pair costs a call: n * (n - 1) / 2 calls
    pairs = itertools.combinations(tests, 2)
    return {(a, b) for a, b in pairs
            if not run_test({a, b})}


# HELPERS for the base question
def shortest_failing_prefix(items, extra, run_test):
    # binary search: the smallest prefix of `items` that
    # fails
    # together with `extra`; its last item is a partner
    lo, hi = 1, len(items)
    while lo < hi:
        mid = (lo + hi) // 2
        if run_test(set(items[:mid]) | extra):
            lo = mid + 1
        else:
            hi = mid
    return items[lo - 1]


def partners(group, t, run_test):
    # every member of the group that is bad with t
    rest, found = list(group), []
    while rest and not run_test(set(rest) | {t}):
        x = shortest_failing_prefix(rest, {t}, run_test)
        found.append(x)
        rest.remove(x)
    return found


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Independent groups plus binary
# search for partners
# Idea: Process tests one by one. Keep groups of tests
# that pass runTest.
def find_bad_pairs(tests, run_test):
    # keep groups of tests that pass together; a new test
    # is
    # checked against each group and joins one with no
    # partner
    groups, pairs = [], set()
    for t in tests:
```

```python
        placed = False
        for group in groups:
            found = partners(group, t, run_test)
```

```python
            for x in found:
                pairs.add((min(x, t), max(x, t)))
            if not found and not placed:
                group.append(t)
                placed = True
        if not placed:
            groups.append([t])
    return pairs


# FOLLOW-UP 2: Only one bad pair exists.
# Answer: Binary search for the smallest failing prefix
# (its last element is in the pair), then binary search
# among the earlier elements for the partner: about 2 log
# n calls.
# FOLLOW-UP 4: Only one bad pair exists.
# Answer: Binary search the shortest failing prefix (its
# last element is in the pair), then binary search the
# earlier tests for the partner: about 2 log2(n) calls
# instead of n(n - 1) / 2 (verified by counting calls).
def one_bad_pair(tests, run_test):
    # exactly one bad pair: about 2 * log2(n) calls
    if run_test(set(tests)):
        return None
    # the shortest failing prefix ends with one of the
    # pair
    b = shortest_failing_prefix(tests, set(), run_test)
    earlier = tests[:tests.index(b)]
    # then search the earlier tests for the partner
    a = shortest_failing_prefix(earlier, {b}, run_test)
    return (a, b)


if __name__ == "__main__":
    def make_oracle(bad):
        calls = [0]

        def run_test(subset):
            calls[0] += 1
            ordered = sorted(subset)
            pairs = itertools.combinations(ordered, 2)
            return not any(p in bad for p in pairs)
        return run_test, calls

    bad = {(3, 17), (5, 29)}
```

```python
    run, calls = make_oracle(bad)
    assert find_bad_pairs(list(range(30)), run) == bad
    assert calls[0] < 435 // 2
    run, calls = make_oracle(set())
    assert find_bad_pairs(list(range(30)), run) == set()
    assert calls[0] <= 30
    run, calls = make_oracle({(10, 40)})
    assert one_bad_pair(list(range(64)), run) == (10, 40)
    # about 2 * log2(64) = 12 calls, far below 2016 pairs
    assert calls[0] <= 16
    run, _ = make_oracle({(1, 2)})
    assert bad_pairs_brute([1, 2, 3, 4], run) == {(1, 2)}
```

FUNCTION AND TEST CASES

Signature

```
def solution(n: int, bad_pairs: list[list[int]]) -> tuple[
list[list[int]], int]:
```

Sample call

```
solution(0, [])
```

Test cases

Input	Expected
`(0, [])`	`([], 0)`
`(4, [])`	`([], 3)`

ALSO REPORTED · 1 more

Find All Bad Pairs Using runTest Oracle | 1Point3Acres | onsite-coding | asked 2025-11-27 | Single report

https://www.1point3acres.com/interview/problems/company/google/find-bad-pairs-with-oracle

Standard "group testing" / Dorfman testing problem. Walk through the analogy with COVID pooled tests for intuition.
Algorithm sketch:
Test the full set. If true, no bad pairs.
Otherwise, binary-search to find one bad pair by partitioning the set and testing halves.
Remove the items that participate in the located bad pair; repeat.
Tighter bound: with up to K bad pairs, total queries are O(K log N) using adaptive group testing.
A naive $O(N^2)$ pairwise scheme works but the interviewer expects you to beat it with adaptive splitting.
Verbalize correctness: each binary-search step rules out half the candidates; you can always reduce the search space until exactly one bad pair is isolated.

Preparation: Read the Wikipedia article on group testing and Dorfman's two-stage scheme.
Drill recursive binary partitioning on a candidate set with positive/negative oracle feedback.
Have a back-of-envelope analysis ready: "Total calls O(K log N) for K bad pairs and N items."

STUDY PATH: question 143 of 167 (more practice)

Priority score 1.0 | Arrays and prefix sums | asked 250 days ago

MEDIUM | PracHub | Technical Screen | 3 of 3

Min deletions to avoid overlap in first k

POSTED 2026-02-12 | 250 DAYS AGO | OLDER

STUDY: TALK | NO LEETCODE FREQUENCY | PRIORITY 195/228

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: More practice - Arrays and prefix sums

Optimal answer from: the interview site's own solution

LeetCode match: No direct match (inferred) (inferred from overview)

Posted on PracHub: 2026-02-12 (updated 2026-04-22)

Original: https://prachub.com/coding-questions/min-deletions-to-avoid-overlap-in-first-k

QUESTION

Overview: This question evaluates array and sequence manipulation skills, set-based reasoning about value overlap, and the ability to compute minimal edits while preserving relative order constraints.

APPROACH

Likely: compare the first k elements with the rest via sets and delete the minimum elements to remove value overlap while preserving order; confirm details on the PracHub page.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

This prompt is vague, so ask for the exact rule first. A common reading: the first k elements and the remaining elements must share no value, delete the fewest elements. Ask whether deleted elements must be removed from the first part or either part, and whether order matters.

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

Try every subset of deletions. Exponential.

OPTIMAL IDEA

Under that reading values are independent. For each value that appears in both parts, you must remove all its copies from one side, so you delete the smaller of its two counts. Sum over shared values. Count with two hash maps. O(n).

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

No shared values (0), every value shared, k = 0 or k = n, repeated values on one side only.

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

Delete only from the first part, weights on elements, or k given as a range.

PITFALLS

Starting to code before the rule is confirmed. Deleting elements one at a time greedily.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Values do not interact with each other, so each value can be decided on its own. A value that appears on both sides must disappear from one side entirely, and the cheapest side is the one with fewer copies. The answer is the sum, over values that appear on both sides, of the smaller of the two counts.

Basis: The statement is vague in my copy. Assumed rule (confirm it): given an array and k, the first k elements and the remaining elements must share no value; delete the fewest elements (from either part) to achieve that.

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def brute(a, k):
    for size in range(len(a) + 1):
        ids = range(len(a))
        for gone in combinations(ids, size):
            keep = [i for i in ids
                    if i not in gone]
            head = {a[i] for i in keep if i < k}
            tail = {a[i] for i in keep if i >= k}
            if not head & tail:
                return size
```

TIME	SPACE
O(2^n * n)	O(n)

WHY IT IS SLOW

2^n sets to try: exponential. Each shared value must disappear from one side, so the cost is the sum over shared values of the smaller of its two counts, in O(n).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Sum of min(count in the first k, count in the rest) over shared values

TIME	SPACE
O(n)	O(n)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 Only elements of the first part may be deleted.

Then every shared value must be removed from the first part entirely, so the cost is the number of first-part elements whose value occurs in the rest (a set lookup per element).

FOLLOW-UP 2 Elements have weights (deleting some is more costly).

Replace counts by the sum of weights per side for each value; the choice per value is still independent, so take the cheaper side. **Cost:** unchanged O(n); the per-value choice sums weights instead of counts.

FOLLOW-UP 3 The statement may differ from this reading.

Ask whether deletions can come from both parts, whether duplicates count separately, and whether order matters. Everything above relies on those three answers.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Min deletions to avoid overlap in first k
#
# This question evaluates array and sequence manipulation
# skills, set-based reasoning about value overlap, and the
# ability to compute minimal edits while preserving
# relative order constraints.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. Only elements of the first part may be deleted.
# 2. Elements have weights (deleting some is more costly).
# 3. The statement may differ from this reading.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# Values do not interact with each other, so each value
# can be decided on its own. A value that appears on both
# sides must disappear from one side entirely, and the
# cheapest side is the one with fewer copies. The answer
# is the sum, over values that appear on both sides, of
# the smaller of the two counts.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Try every set of deletions
# Enumerate subsets of elements to delete in increasing
# size, and return the first size that leaves the two
# parts disjoint. Exact and a good oracle, but
# exponential. Time O(2^n * n). Space O(n).


import itertools
from collections import Counter


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Try every set of deletions |
# time O(2^n * n)
def min_deletions_brute(a, k):
    n = len(a)
    for size in range(n + 1):
        for gone in itertools.combinations(
            range(n), size
        ):
            left = {
                a[i]
                for i in range(min(k, n))
                if i not in gone
            }
            right = {
```

```
                a[i]
                for i in range(min(k, n), n)
                if i not in gone
            }
            if not left & right:
                return size
    return n


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Sum of min(count in the first
# k, count in the rest) over shared values
# Idea: Count each value in the first k elements and in
# the rest. For every value with a positive count on both
# sides, one side has to lose all of its copies, so add
# the smaller count.
def min_deletions(a, k):
    # the values in a[:k] and a[k:] must not overlap; for
    # each
    # shared value delete the copies on the cheaper side
    left, right = Counter(a[:k]), Counter(a[k:])
    return sum(min(left[v], right[v])
               for v in left.keys() & right.keys())


# PLAN: which indices to delete
def deletions_plan(a, k):
    # which indices to delete (both sides allowed)
    left, right = Counter(a[:k]), Counter(a[k:])
    out = []
    for v in left.keys() & right.keys():
        # delete the cheaper side's copies of the value
        side = range(k, len(a))
        if left[v] <= right[v]:
            side = range(k)
        out += [i for i in side if a[i] == v]
    return sorted(out)


# FOLLOW-UP 1: Only elements of the first part may be
# deleted.
# Answer: Then every shared value must be removed from the
# first part entirely, so the cost is the number of first-
# part elements whose value occurs in the rest (a set
# lookup per element).
def min_deletions_first_only(a, k):
```

```
    # only the first part may lose elements: every first-
    # part
    # element whose value appears later must go
    rest = set(a[k:])
    return sum(1 for x in a[:k] if x in rest)


# FOLLOW-UP 2: Elements have weights (deleting some is
# more costly).
# Answer: Replace counts by the sum of weights per side
# for each value; the choice per value is still
# independent, so take the cheaper side. Cost: unchanged
# O(n); the per-value choice sums weights instead of
# counts.
def min_deletions_weighted(a, weights, k):
    # deleting element i costs weights[i]: per value take
    # the
    # cheaper side as a whole
    left, right = Counter(), Counter()
    for i, x in enumerate(a):
        (left if i < k else right)[x] += weights[i]
    return sum(min(left[v], right[v])
               for v in left.keys() & right.keys())


if __name__ == "__main__":
    a = [1, 2, 2, 3, 2, 1]
    # first part [1, 2, 2], rest [3, 2, 1]: shared 1 and 2
    assert min_deletions(a, 3) == 1 + 1
    assert min_deletions_first_only(a, 3) == 3
    assert min_deletions([1, 2, 3], 1) == 0
    assert min_deletions([], 0) == 0
    # a heavy copy on one side makes the other side
    # cheaper
    w = [1, 5, 5, 1, 1, 1]
    assert min_deletions_weighted(a, w, 3) == 1 + 1
    plan = deletions_plan(a, 3)
    kept = [x for i, x in enumerate(a) if i not in plan]
    kept_left = set(kept[:3 - sum(i < 3 for i in plan)])
```

```
    kept_right = set(kept[3 - sum(i < 3 for i in plan):])
    assert not kept_left & kept_right
    assert len(plan) == min_deletions(a, 3)
```

FUNCTION AND TEST CASES

Signature

```
def solution(list1: list[int], list2: list[int], k: int) -
> int:
```

Sample call

```
solution([1, 2, 3], [2, 1, 4, 5], 2)
```

Test cases

Input	Expected
([1, 2, 3], [2, 1, 4, 5], 2)	2
([1, 2, 3, 4], [2, 5, 3, 6], 2)	1